

Targeting Community Revitalization Investment in Illinois

An analysis of housing affordability, vacancy, poverty, and population trends across 102 Illinois counties using ACS 5-Year Estimates (2014-2022)

Chris Kucewicz | Independent Research Project | 2026

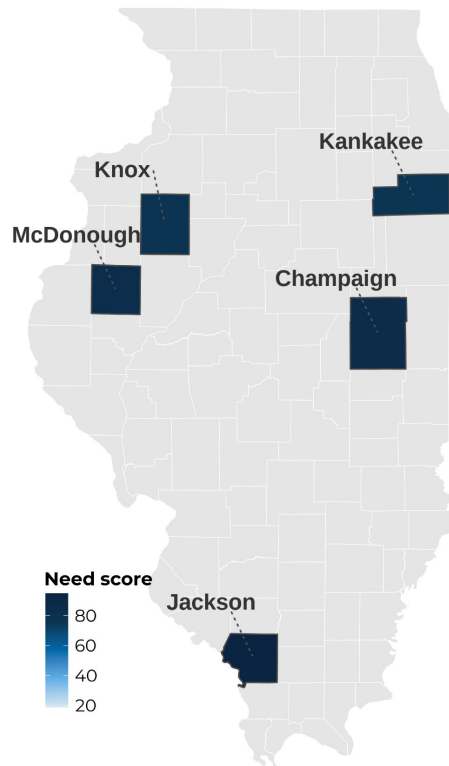
Data: U.S. Census Bureau 5-year Estimates

Which counties would benefit most from targeted community revitalization investment?

All 102 IL counties scored across 5 indicators: rent burden, price-to-income, poverty, homeownership, and vacancy.

Top 5 Counties by Revitalization Need

Composite score: rent burden + price-to-income + poverty + low homeownership + vacancy (2022)



Top 5 counties by revitalization need

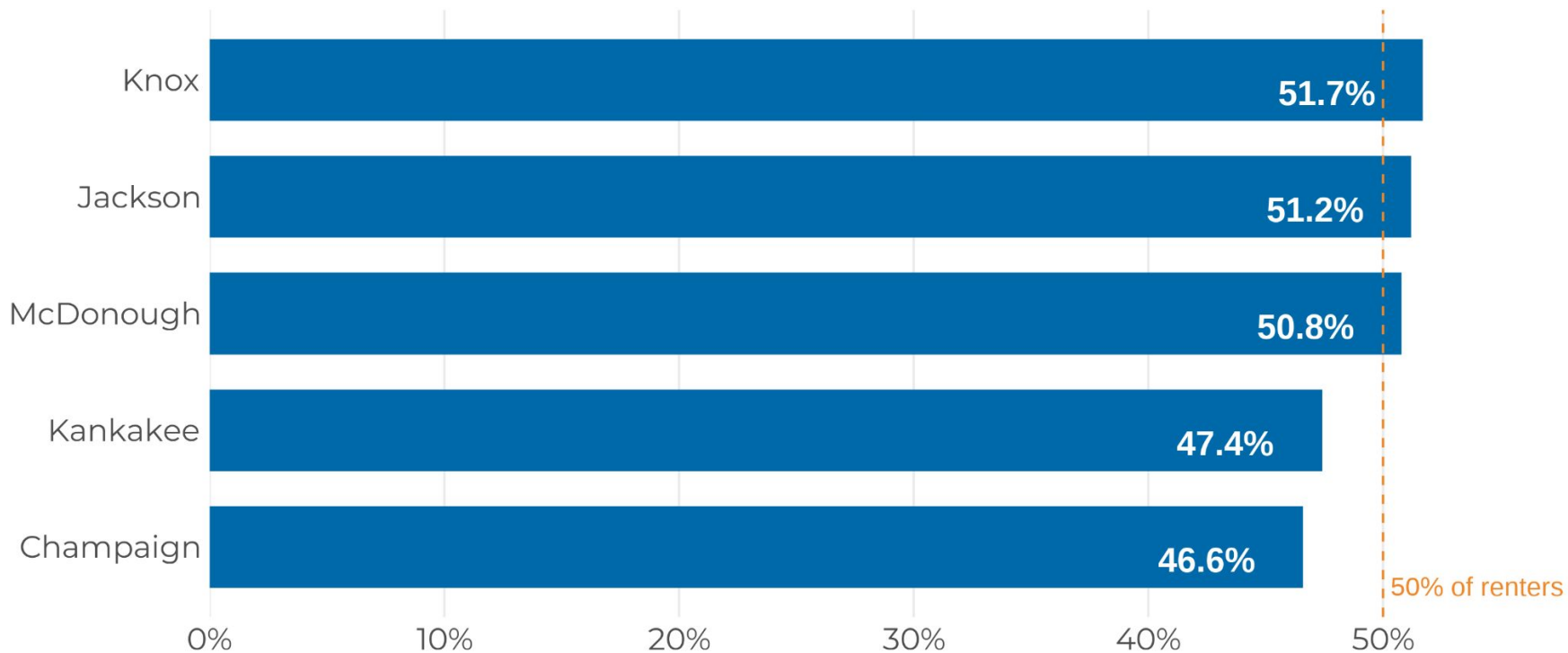
Composite score and component metrics (2022)

County	Score	Rent burden %	Price:income	Poverty %	Homeown. %	Vacancy %
Jackson	95.0	51.2	2.75	23.0	48.5	16.9
Champaign	85.5	46.6	3.15	18.7	53.5	11.7
McDonough	85.1	50.8	2.05	19.8	61.3	15.0
Knox	76.8	51.7	1.93	16.3	68.7	12.9
Kankakee	76.2	47.4	2.70	14.0	68.1	10.4

Source: ACS 5-Year Estimates, 2022

Residents in these Communities are Cost Burdened

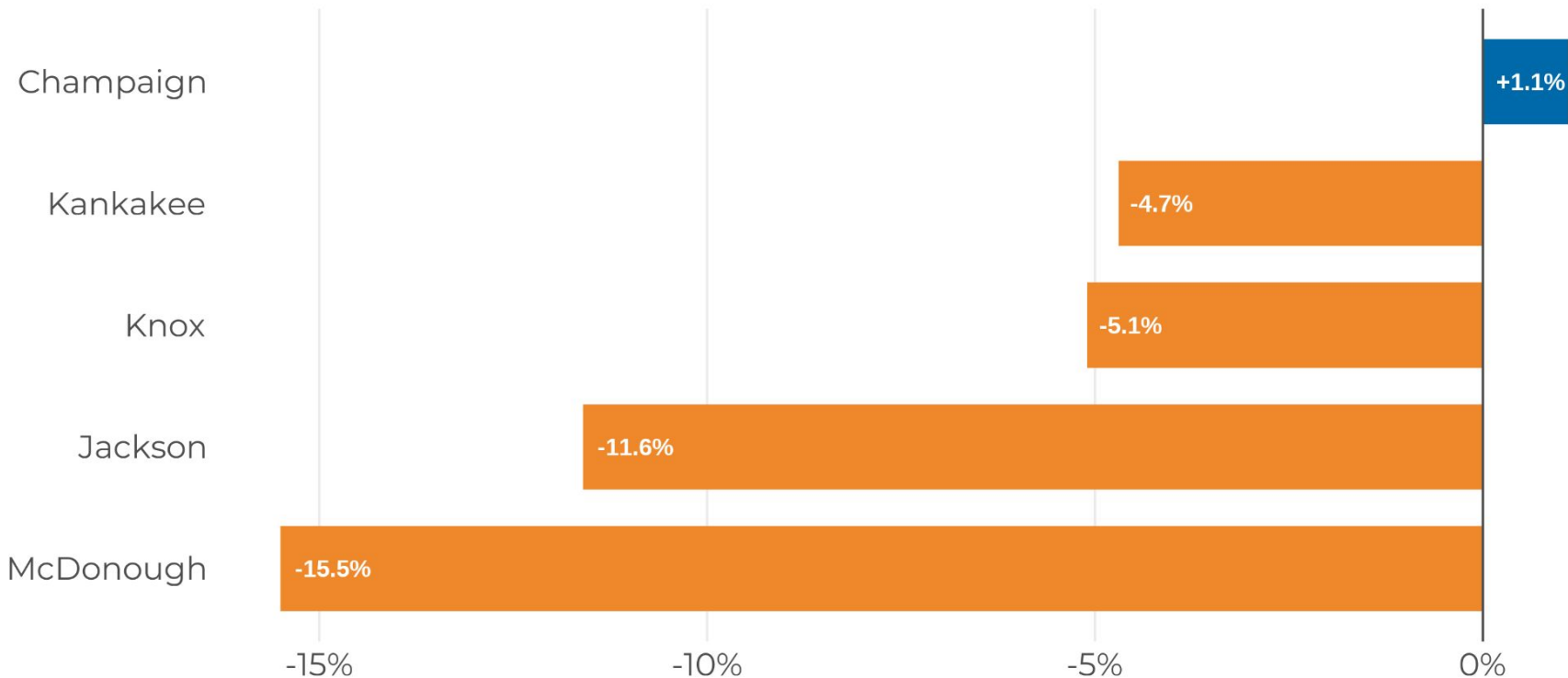
% of renters spending 30%+ on rent



Source: ACS 5-Year Estimates, 2022 | U.S. Census Bureau

Most of these Communities are Losing Residents

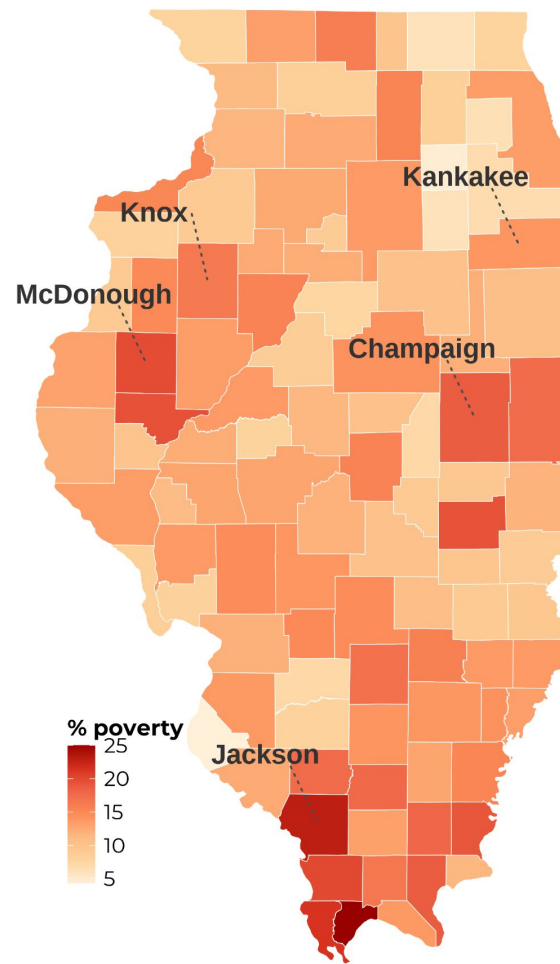
Population change from 2014 to 2022 in top revitalization-need counties



Source: ACS 5-Year Estimates, 2014 & 2022 | U.S. Census Bureau

These Communities Face Compounding Economic and Housing Pressures

Poverty rate by county (2022)

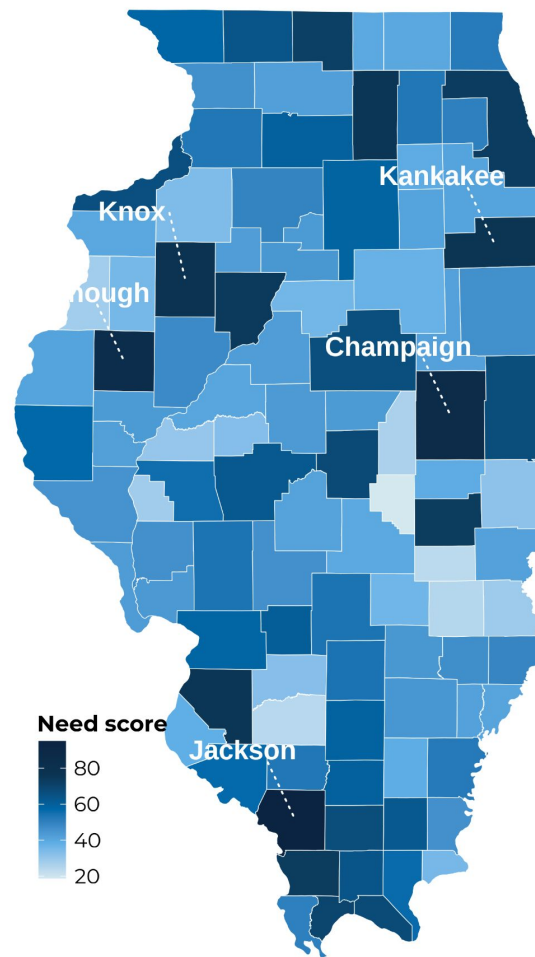


Appendix

Additional maps and methodology

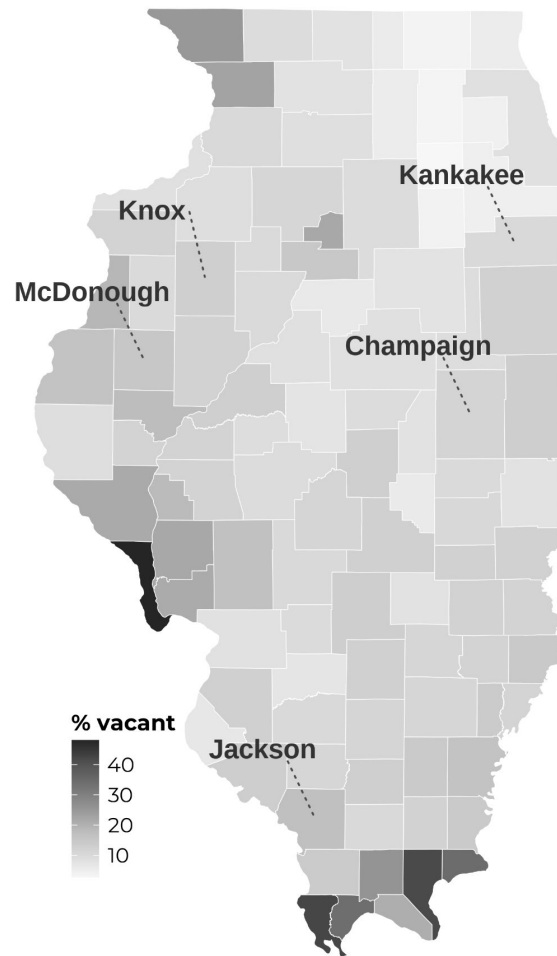
Composite Need Score - All Counties

rent burden + price-to-income + poverty + low homeownership + vacancy (2022)



Vacancy Rate

By county (2022)



Methodology

Data source: U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey 5-Year Estimates (2014, 2016, 2018, 2020, 2022)

Geography: All 102 Illinois counties

Composite score components (5 variables, equally weighted):

- Rent burden %
 - a. Higher = more renters spending 30%+ of income on rent
- Price-to-income ratio
 - a. Higher = homes less affordable relative to income
- Poverty rate %
 - a. Higher = greater economic vulnerability
- Homeownership rate % (inverted)
 - a. Lower homeownership = more need
- Vacancy rate %
 - a. Higher = more deteriorating/abandoned housing stock

Scoring: Each variable percentile-ranked across all 102 counties, summed, and divided by 5 for a 0-100 scale.

Full code and data: https://github.com/ckucewicz/housing_affordability_model

Considerations and Constraints

1. **ACS 5-year estimates are rolling averages:** the "2022" data reflects 2018-2022, not a single point in time
2. **County-level analysis masks local variation:** conditions within a county like Cook County can vary dramatically by neighborhood
3. **Equal weighting is a methodological choice:** assigning different weights to the five composite variables could produce different rankings
4. **Missing dimensions:** housing stock condition, age of housing, and homelessness are relevant to revitalization but not captured in ACS data
5. **Relative ranking, not absolute need:** percentile scoring identifies which counties are worst relative to each other, but doesn't measure whether a county meets an objective threshold of need
6. **Scores are not population-weighted:** designed to surface small communities that may otherwise be overlooked



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**Thank you! I
welcome any
questions or
feedback.**